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Ethics

ETH 0008

Reflection

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How can our attachment to, or craving for worldly pleasure cause suffering? Cite your personal experience/s.

Humankind tends to feel intense craving for worldly pleasure is a normal human part of behaviour as it is driven by various internal and external factors, including emotionally and physically driven cravings, and material cravings. The cravings, being a normal behaviour, can cause suffering when done without being mindful. The action itself is not the real issue, but the lack of moral discipline that gives them suffering without them realizing.

This suffering was mainly caused by the attachment to the pleasure it gives them. When one craves something and gets attached to it, they tend to crave it again, leading to a continuous, unhealthy cycle, becoming an obsession. This behavior drives a person away from attaining the highest, permanent, and long-term happiness by relying on temporary joy alone.

From my experience, I tend to crave sweets a lot. I used to crave only after eating a meal, but now, I would buy every time I am craving, even every day, I strongly crave that I feel uneasy without eating sweets. This craving leads to the point that I would buy it anytime just because I want to, ignoring the effects of consuming too much sugar, just to satisfy myself. Aside from affecting my health, I have been spending too much money on it when I am supposed to save. By reflecting, I could have saved a lot and spent the money on more important things. With this, it is in fact that too many cravings lead to suffering that we do not even realize until it gets worse.

These days, when I am supposed to study, finish my tasks, and do my responsibilities as a student, I spend my time resting, sleeping, doom scrolling on social media, and doing anything just to avoid doing so, and to avoid academic stress. Due to this desire to be stress-free, I tend to be more stressed as due dates come near. Due to stress from the workload that made me crave for leisure time and pleasure, it just leads to more suffering and repeated regret.

With this, after learning about Buddhist ethics, it helped me to be more mindful of my desires, to practice balance to avoid being controlled by strong cravings, and to prevent undesired suffering. I realized that real happiness and fulfillment do not come from temporary joy and satisfaction of cravings, but from something that does not give suffering. By reflecting and being mindful of my desires and actions, I will be able to break the cycle of attachment and regret. This understanding helps lead to living a more meaningful life, not just by attaining a short term happiness.